helped me. Now, how can you expect me to bail you out?' One Congress MP jocularly remarked, 'Even those who wanted to help would see the opinion poll figures and rush back home with the money. No one wants to waste cash on losers!'

By contrast, a senior BJP leader was receiving so much money that bundles of 1000-rupee notes were lined up along the walls at his house. There was so much cash floating around for the BJP that not only did it fund several candidates, some of it was eventually returned to the party coffers. 'I had never seen anything like it. Not a single high net worth individual or corporate we contacted said no to us,' the leader told me later. It wasn't just the big corporates; even several small- and medium-size enterprises were willing to give the BJP around Rs 10 to 20 crore each. Also, all corporates with large investments in Gujarat lined up firmly behind Modi. They included groups like the Ruias of Essar who had found themselves under the legal scanner in the 2G scam. Non-resident Indians, especially non-resident Gujaratis, were also willing to pump money into the BJP campaign.

Did the contrasting financial positions of the two main parties make a difference in the campaign? Yes, to some extent. Generally, parties like the Congress and the BJP have a 'graded' system—'winnable' candidates are provided a sum of around Rs 2 crore from the party funds, while the next category gets Rs 1 crore. The balance amount is expected to be raised by the candidates, with Rs 5 to 10 crore being the average cost for fighting an election (in states like Andhra and Maharashtra, it can go up to Rs 15 to 20 crore, but is less in north and east India; while urban seats are more expensive than rural ones).

'We had to rely on our individual connections more than ever before to raise money,' a defeated Congress MP told me. In contrast, the BJP told their candidates that any fund crunch would be compensated by the party. They would also not have to spend a single paisa on any Modi campaign in their constituency—the leader had a sufficient war chest to manage his entire campaign blitz.